Public Housing and Local Housing Programs

East Detroit | Detroit and Portland governance cases

City and County of East Detroit

November 2030

Public housing and local housing programs

East Detroit has two housing institutions: the City Housing Division and the independent Regional Housing Authority. Detroit and Portland provide detailed examples of how these responsibilities are divided. The historical cases below include reporting through November 2026. Each case finding is linked to its original agency record, public document or published investigation.

East Detroit’s two housing institutions

1. **City and County of East Detroit Housing Division (EDHD).** A city-county department, answerable to the executive and council through appropriations and public records. It runs local housing policy and programs: financing development and preservation, tenant and homeowner assistance, homelessness prevention, and coordination with planning and human services. It may manage locally financed housing or contracts, but cannot allocate an independent authority’s federal vouchers.
2. **East Detroit Regional Housing Authority (EDRHA).** An independent public housing authority with its own commission, management, budgets, federal housing agreements, property and rental-assistance operations, and accountability duties. Modeled

on Home Forward, it also serves participating communities beyond the city-county. It administers federal housing assistance and its portfolio, plus local or regional programs where agreements allow. The city-county cannot direct its board or take its records just because it serves city residents.

Both serve many of the same residents while maintaining separate budgets, boards, programs and records. Households can encounter repeated intake or verification. Coordination requires a defined agreement between the agencies.

Detroit: a city department and a separate housing commission

Detroit HRD: a city department

Detroit's Housing and Revitalization Department (HRD) is a city office and the closest real precedent for EDHD. According to the city, it directs housing policy, manages HUD entitlement funds and city housing investments, finances new housing and preservation, supports homeowners and renters, and works with partners on homelessness. The city names its partnership with the independent Detroit Housing Commission. [D1] [D2]

Detroit's *2025–2030 Affordable Housing Strategy* targets preserving 10,000 affordable units and building 3,000 over five years. These are policy targets, not results, and are not scaled to East Detroit. [D3]

Detroit Housing Commission: separate and federally accountable

The Detroit Housing Commission (DHC) is a public housing authority, governed separately from HRD.

- **Federal takeover.** After administrative, financial and management failures, HUD took control of DHC's operations on July 7, 2005. [D4]

- **Transition plan.** In January 2012, HUD announced a plan to return DHC to local control, requiring sustainable governance, an oversight agreement and performance improvements. [D5]
- **Return to local control.** DHC states that HUD released it from the recovery administrator on March 13, 2015. [D6]
- **Board.** Under Michigan law, a five-member board appointed by Detroit's mayor governs DHC. At least one member must be a resident of subsidized housing. Mayoral appointment does not make DHC a city department. [D6]

Detroit's operating problems (reported findings)

- **Income and voucher recertification.** Outlier Media reported that understaffing caused long federal voucher backlogs. In April 2023, 221 of 1,960 recertifications due were complete. Reporting in 2024 found 1,747 delinquent recertifications still pending despite an outside contractor's help. Pending recertifications can mean wrong rents and subsidies. Landlords reported late payments; some stopped accepting DHC vouchers. [D7] [D8]
- **Capacity and unmet demand.** Outlier reported that for a period the agency used roughly 1,500 fewer vouchers than its capacity, partly for lack of staff. [D8]
- **Vacancy and building condition.** In a 2023 Outlier interview, the interviewer put public housing occupancy at about 78%. Later reporting put vacancy near 23–24% in September 2024, with problems collecting rent and deteriorating buildings. [D9] [D10]
- **Recovery, with limits.** In a 2025 follow-up, Outlier reported that DHC management said it had mostly cleared the recertification backlog. Management also said vacancy had fallen from 24% to 14% and all 15 complexes had passed that year's HUD inspections. The same article reported residents whose problems persisted. These are reported outcomes and management statements for that period, not proof that every resident's problem was resolved. [D11]

A shared digital form cannot fix these problems alone. Staffing, authority, incentives and financing are part of the service.

Portland: Home Forward and the city housing bureau

Home Forward is a public corporation and the housing authority for Portland and Multnomah County, including Gresham and east Multnomah County. It states that it is not part of Portland city government. It runs housing assistance, affordable properties and related services, plus some programs for the city, the county and other partners. [H1]

Board and accountability

Home Forward has a nine-member volunteer commission: four Portland representatives, two from Gresham, two from Multnomah County and one housing-program participant. The board sets policy, approves the budget and hires the executive director. The appointing governments shape who serves; they do not run daily operations. [H2]

Portland’s own Housing Bureau finances affordable housing, supports preservation and runs local housing policies. Like Detroit’s HRD and DHC, Portland pairs a city bureau with a separate authority, the pattern East Detroit follows. [H3]

Federal flexibility: Moving to Work

Home Forward joined HUD’s Moving to Work (MTW) demonstration on April 1, 1999. MTW gives selected public housing authorities limited flexibility over funding and administration, within federal conditions and reporting. It gives a city no unrestricted access to federal records and guarantees neither more housing nor sound management. In October 2026, Home Forward was reportedly considering changing its MTW participation, partly to address voucher funding. [H4] [H5]

An operating and financial crisis

Table 1. Home Forward, 2025–2026: what was reported, and when

When	Reported finding	What to examine
November–December 2025	A November vacancy report described 956 of 6,847 units vacant, about 14%. Later coverage rounded the count to 955. The agency cited damaged units, market conditions and other causes. A high vacancy count does not mean every unit was ready to rent. [H6]	Unit condition, affordability, waiting lists, location, eligibility and leasing speed
February 2026	Data supplied by Home Forward showed an average of 185 days to fill a vacancy in 2025. Buildings it managed directly averaged 172 days; contractor-run buildings had different averages. [H7]	Who owns each handoff, management contracts, how long units are actually available to lease
February–March 2026	Reporting identified high vacancy, lost rent revenue, weakening debt-service coverage, tenant safety concerns and uneven performance among contracted property managers. A March report described one manager averaging 292 days to fill units. [H8] [H9]	Contractor oversight, financial feedback loops, resident safety
April–May 2026	Willamette Week reported more than $100,000 in agency-funded CEO travel during 2023–2025, based on public records. On April 29, Home Forward announced that CEO Ivory Mathews would resign effective May 1; Michael Buonocore became interim chief. Officials and residents questioned the board's oversight. [H10] [H11]	Board scrutiny, conflicts of interest, executive reporting, leadership and public accountability
August 2026	The Oregon Government Ethics Commission voted to investigate the former CEO's travel spending. The vote opened a full investigation, which is not a finding of misconduct. [H12]	Accusation vs. preliminary grounds vs. formal finding
October 26, 2026	Home Forward's interim director estimated a $38 million budget gap for 2027. The director said the 2026 shortfall had grown from an earlier estimate of $13.8 million to nearly $38 million. A possible $28 million HUD shortfall payment for 2026 was not guaranteed. Options discussed: staff cuts, lower administrative spending, changing tenants' share of rent, and reconsidering MTW terms. The proposed tenant changes were expected to affect 12,356 households. [H5]	Forecasting, federal-fund dependence, cost shifts to tenants, who may change benefits

Intense unmet need can coexist with all of these problems, and no single figure shows the cause. Vacant units include ones needing work, ones with different affordability restrictions, and ones whose rents may not compete with some market offers. Ask what causes each delay or vacancy.

An authority with public representation and formal controls can still fail at oversight. MTW flexibility cannot replace accurate financial reporting, adequate staffing, property performance or a functioning board.

Comparison of housing authority models

Table 2. Detroit, Portland and East Detroit compared

Question	Detroit: city department + DHC	Portland: Housing Bureau + Home Forward	East Detroit
Municipal housing office	HRD: policy, investment, production, preservation, homelessness [D1]	Housing Bureau: finance, local protections [H3]	EDHD; must take part
Separate authority	DHC: federally accountable; five-member board appointed by the mayor [D6]	Home Forward: independent public corporation; nine commissioners, several jurisdictions [H1] [H2]	EDRHA, independent and regional
Who it serves	Detroit, with federal and development partners	Portland, Gresham, rest of Multnomah County	East Detroit plus participating neighbors
Separate sources of money	City and entitlement funds vs. authority assistance and property finance	Local funds vs. federal vouchers, property revenue, other sources	Separate funds; terms for joint projects
Failures highlighted	Recertification backlogs, staffing, occupancy, inspections and property problems [D8] [D11]	Vacancy turnover, debt pressure, forecast gap, governance and oversight [H7] [H5]	None assumed; examine whatever local evidence exists
Possible cooperation	Development, preservation, homelessness referrals and resident services	Housing finance, shared projects, landlord relations and property operations	Defined intake, referrals, local assistance, housing placement, record correction, financial coordination
Why they may disagree	Independent duties and federal voucher administration	Regional constituency, separate board, funding restrictions	EDRHA may refuse integration or ask for contract conditions

What overlap tells us

- Savings to investigate: duplicate intake, repeated address checks, conflicting program directories, untracked staff referrals,

repeated landlord requests, inconsistent vacancy reporting, and help desks with no clear handoff.

- Work that should stay separate: program-specific federal eligibility and appeals; HUD voucher funding; property ownership and debt; inspections and habitability; city appropriations; regional board accountability; and resident confidentiality.
- A possible harm: more referrals to programs with no funding, staff, available unit or willing landlord. Faster screening can lengthen a queue when the bottleneck is housing supply or leasing, not intake.

How the agencies encounter the same household

Consider a household that is behind on rent and may lose its home.

Table 3. Who could do what for a household facing eviction

Step	City Housing Division could…	Regional Housing Authority could…	Other participants
Understand the need	Offer city-funded prevention, navigation help or a referral	Identify an existing voucher, lease or property relationship, where authorized	Household, landlord, advocates
Check address and identity	Use a municipal address or residency service under adopted rules	Use its own records and HUD verification rules	GIS, county human services, HUD
Apply program rules	Decide eligibility for local funds	Decide eligibility, rent calculations, and voucher or lease rules	State or federal program administrators
Find available help	Allocate a limited city-funded grant	Confirm voucher budget, available property, subsidy and inspection requirements	Finance, property manager, landlord
Deliver a result	Pay a qualifying landlord, or issue a local decision or referral	Issue or adjust assistance, or offer a qualifying unit under program terms	Resident, landlord, courts where relevant
Correct errors and handle complaints	Correct the local case; allow appeals under city rules	Correct its voucher or tenancy record; use the required review process	Original record holder, any independent appeal body

A shared application or verified-status exchange would require agreement on which records are sent, for what purpose, and who corrects errors. Each agency remains responsible for its own income verification and eligibility decisions.

Federal limits on “one-click housing”

One-click housing approval depends on several separate federal and local requirements.

- **Income verification.** HUD already runs the Enterprise Income Verification (EIV) system, using income and benefit data from authorized federal arrangements. Public housing authorities use it under program rules. It is not a general city tax or payroll registry for citywide benefits. See HUD’s description and 24 CFR § 5.233. [F1] [F2]
- **Vouchers.** Housing Choice Vouchers require federal verification and reexamination, so an income flag alone does not show a funded voucher or suitable unit exists. A city may fund its own rent relief, but an interface change cannot create more federal vouchers. [F1] [F2] [F3]
- **Eviction court.** Automatic court stays require legal authority beyond a housing service. Court rules, notice, case status, landlord action and judicial authority need an actual legal basis. A housing authority’s automated referral cannot cancel a court case.

Reliable verification can reduce repeat paperwork. The agencies must still settle who operates the process and who handles corrections.

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